



CUE SYNC

F O R G R A N D M A

User Manual

VERSION 1.1.0

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1 Introduction

Cue Sync is a show-control playback system. It plays the show's audio and transmits MIDI Show Control (MSC) and MIDI messages to a lighting console at predetermined positions on each track's timeline, removing the need for SMPTE timecode or dedicated synchronisation hardware.

1.1 Operating model

Cue Sync separates **programming** from **execution**. Tracks are imported and cues are placed in **Edit Mode**, which exposes the full timeline, channel processing and cue parameters. The show is run from **Show Mode**, a reduced interface that presents the running order, transport and live status, and limits the actions available to the operator.

Switching between the two modes changes only the presentation. Cue data, processing and transport state are shared and persist across the switch.

1.2 System requirements

Component	Requirement
Operating system	Windows 10 / 11 (64-bit); macOS on Intel or Apple Silicon
MIDI	USB MIDI interface, or a virtual MIDI port routed to the console
Audio	Any output device recognised by the operating system
Network (optional)	Local Wi-Fi, required only for the phone remote

1.3 Conventions in this manual

Menu paths are written as **Menu** → **Item**. Interface labels appear in **bold**. Three kinds of callout are used:

TIP Recommended practice that saves time or reduces risk.

NOTE Background information that clarifies behaviour.

CAUTION A condition that can affect a performance if overlooked.

2 Installation & Activation

2.1 Installing

Platform	Package	Procedure
Windows	CueSync-Setup-Windows.exe	Run the installer and follow the prompts. Desktop and Start-menu shortcuts are created.
macOS (Apple Silicon)	CueSync-Mac-AppleSilicon.zip	For M1/M2/M3/M4 Macs. Unzip and move Cue Sync.app to Applications.

Platform	Package	Procedure
macOS (Intel)	CueSync-Mac-Intel.zip	For Intel Macs. Unzip and move Cue Sync.app to Applications.

CAUTION On macOS, open the application the first time with **right-click** → **Open**, not a double-click. A double-click is blocked by Gatekeeper for applications distributed outside the App Store. If macOS still refuses, run `xattr -cr "/Applications/Cue Sync.app"` in Terminal.

TIP Install the build that matches the processor. The Intel build runs on Apple Silicon only through Rosetta translation, which is slower and uses more memory.

2.2 Activation

On first launch the activation window displays a **Machine ID** derived from the computer's hardware. Provide this ID to your supplier to obtain a serial number.

Figure 1. Activation window. The Machine ID is unique to this computer.

1. Enter the licensee name and e-mail address.
2. Enter the serial number exactly as issued.
3. Select **Activate**.

NOTE Each installation is activated independently. Reinstalling the application requires the serial to be entered again. The same serial remains valid on the same computer, because it is bound to that computer's Machine ID.

3 Projects & Files

3.1 Startup

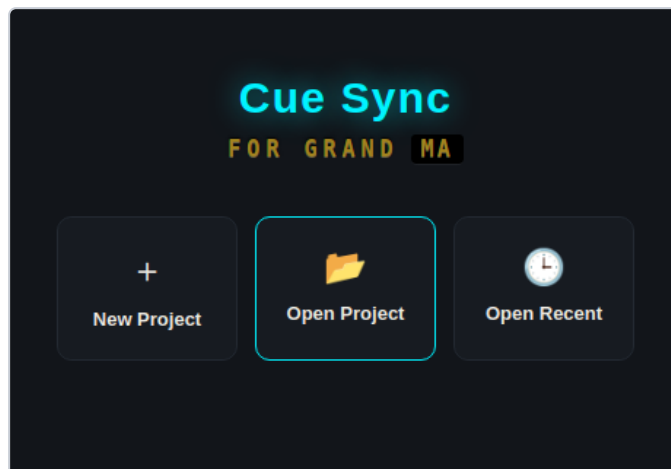


Figure 2. Startup window: create a new project or reopen a recent one.

3.2 Project files

Projects are stored as **.cuesync** files, which are associated with Cue Sync and display its icon. The file records the running order, cues, processing settings and references to media. Projects saved in the earlier **.json** format remain readable.

Command	Function
File → New	Closes the current project and starts an empty one.
File → Open...	Opens a .cuesync or legacy .json project.
File → Save	Writes the project to its current file; prompts for a location the first time.
File → Save As...	Writes the project to a new file and location.
File → Backup Project...	Writes the project and a copy of every media file into a chosen folder.
File → Import Songs...	Adds audio or video files to the running order.

3.3 Backup Project

Backup Project... produces a self-contained copy of the show. Every media file used by the project is copied into the selected folder under its original filename, and the saved project refers to those copies rather than to their original locations. The folder can be moved to another drive or computer and opened directly.

- Files sharing the same name are kept separately; the second receives a numeric suffix, for example *Intro (2).wav*.
- Media imported by drag-and-drop, which has no original path on disk, is written using the song's name.
- If a media file cannot be located, the backup completes and a warning lists the affected songs.

TIP

Create a backup before travelling to a venue and keep it on a separate drive. It is the only format that carries the media with it.

4 Edit Mode

Edit Mode is the programming environment. It presents every track on a shared timeline together with transport, zoom and per-track processing.

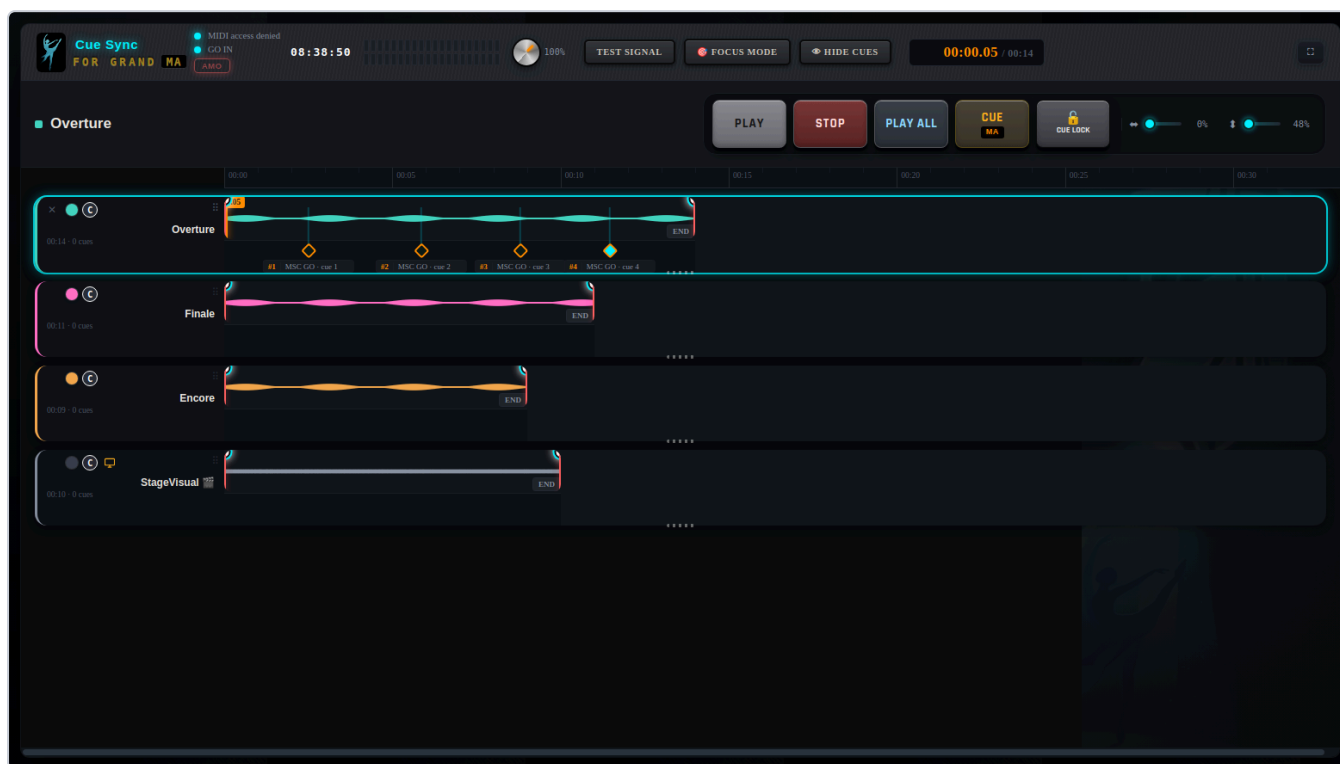


Figure 3. Edit Mode with four tracks, including a video track, and four cues on the selected track.

4.1 Header bar

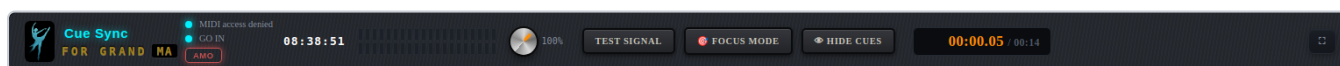


Figure 4. Header bar.

Element	Function
Status indicators	MIDI output state, GO IN (incoming MIDI) and the AMO button, which disconnects MIDI output.
Clock	Current time of day.
Output level	Master output meter and volume knob.
TEST SIGNAL	Transmits a test message to confirm the console link.
FOCUS MODE	Shows only the selected track, enlarged, with its full processing strip.
HIDE CUES	Hides cue markers on the waveforms without deleting them.
Song time	Elapsed and total time of the active song. Select it to open an enlarged, resizable clock window.
Fullscreen	Switches the application to full screen (top-right corner).

4.2 Transport



Figure 5. Transport and zoom controls, aligned to the right of the track row.

Control	Function
PLAY / PAUSE	Starts the active track. While playing the button reads PAUSE and pauses at the current position.
STOP	Stops playback and returns to the start of the track. Double-click to reset every track to its start.
PLAY ALL	When lit, tracks play consecutively in running order without stopping.
CUE / MA	Adds a cue at the playhead position. Shown in red when unavailable.
CUE LOCK	Locks all cues against movement, addition and deletion. Cues continue to fire.
↔ Horizontal zoom	Magnifies the timeline horizontally.
↑↓ Vertical zoom	Adjusts track height.

NOTE The Edit Mode transport uses the same buttons and behaviour as Show Mode, so an operator moving between the two modes sees identical controls.

4.3 Tracks

Each track row contains, from left to right: a remove button, a colour selector, the **C** cue-list button, a video-preview button (video tracks only), the track name, and the waveform. The line beneath the name gives the duration and the number of cues.

Importing

Drag audio or video files onto the window, or use **File** → **Import Songs....** Supported formats include WAV, MP3, AAC, FLAC, OGG, MP4, MOV, WebM and MKV.

Colour

Select the dot at the left of a track to assign a colour. The colour is applied to the waveform, the Show Mode list and the status displays.

TIP Assign one colour family per act or section. Colour is recognised faster than text during a performance.

Trim and fades

- Drag the handles at either end of a waveform to set the playable region (trim).
- Drag the upper handles to set fade-in and fade-out lengths.
- Drag the grip at the left of a row to change the running order.

5 Cues

A cue is a timed MIDI message attached to a position on a track. When the playhead reaches that position during playback, Cue Sync transmits the message.

5.1 Creating cues

1. Select the track.
2. Position the playhead by clicking the waveform.
3. Select **CUE**, or press the keyboard shortcut. The cue is placed at the playhead.

5.2 Cue Inspector and Cue Stack

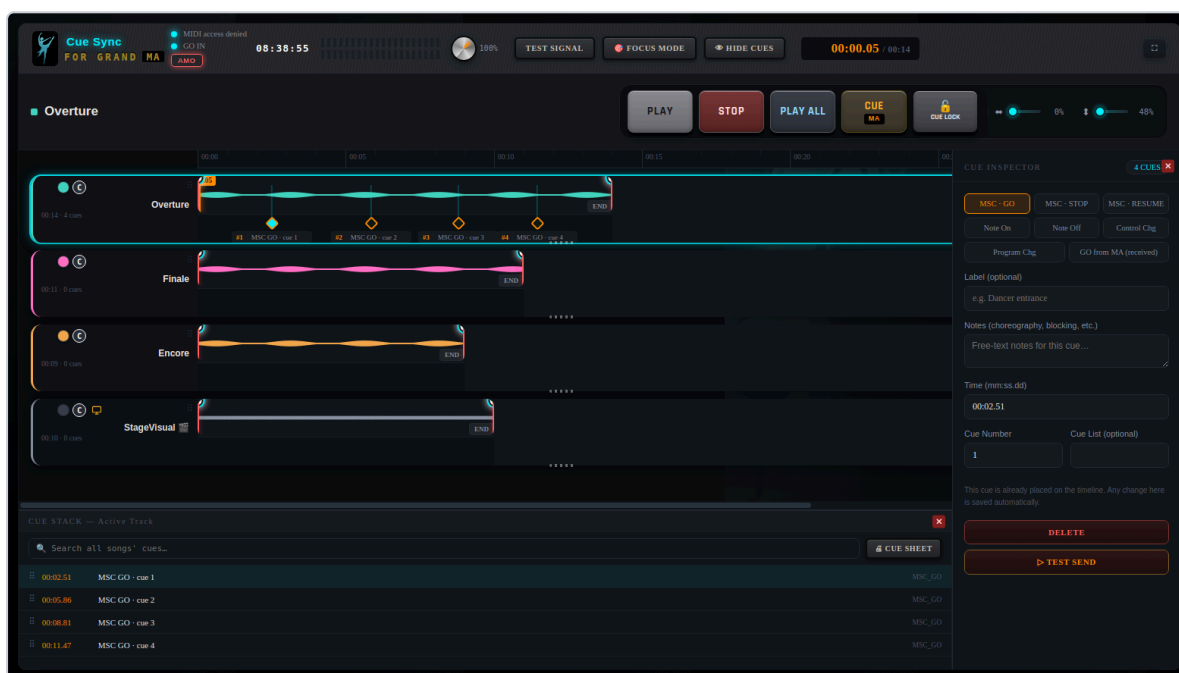


Figure 6. Cue Stack (bottom) and Cue Inspector (right), opened from the Panel menu.

Open the panels from the **Panel** menu. Every panel carries a red ✕ in its corner that closes it.

Parameter	Description
Message type	MSC GO, MSC STOP, MSC RESUME, Note On/Off, Control Change or Program Change.
Cue number / list	Must correspond to the numbering on the console.
Label	Descriptive name shown on the waveform and in the status panel.
Colour	Optional marker colour.
Notes	Free text, for example staging or timing reminders.
Test Send	Transmits the cue immediately without starting playback.

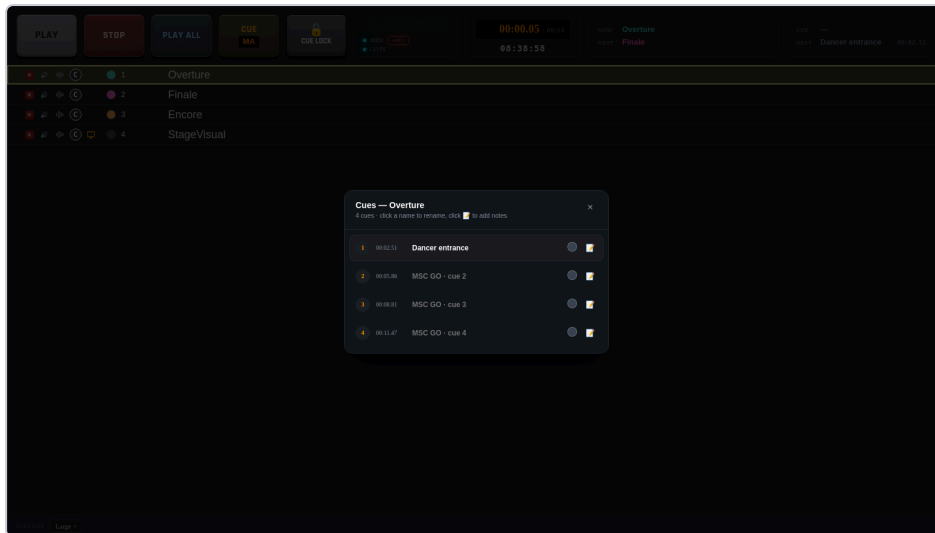


Figure 7. Cue list for a track. Select a name to rename it.

TIP

Name cues after the stage action, for example *Dancer entrance*, rather than the cue number. The label is what the operator reads in the status panel during the show.

5.3 Moving cues

Drag a cue marker along the waveform to change its time. The time updates during the drag and is saved when the mouse is released. A single click on a marker opens it in the Inspector.

CAUTION

Cues cannot be moved or added while **CUE LOCK** is engaged. Engage CUE LOCK once programming is complete.

6 Processing

Each track has an independent processing chain: volume, pan, fades, a five-band parametric equaliser and a compressor.



Figure 8. Focus Mode: the selected track enlarged, with its complete processing strip.

6.1 Channel controls

Control	Function
VOL	Track level, 0–150 %. 100 % is the file's original level.
PAN	Stereo position.
FADE IN / OUT	Fade durations in seconds.
CURVE	Fade shape.

6.2 Equaliser

Drag the five points on the curve to adjust gain at each band. Horizontal movement changes frequency; vertical movement changes gain.

Real-time analyser (RTA)

Select **RTA** in the equaliser header to display a real-time spectrum behind the curve. The analyser shows the signal *after* equalisation and compression, on a logarithmic frequency scale, so the effect of each adjustment is visible directly. It does not alter the audio and has no effect on playback when disabled.

6.3 Compressor

Enable the compressor with **ON** and set the threshold with **THR**. The **GR** meter displays gain reduction in decibels, in real time.

TIP Set levels per track in Focus Mode before the show. Balanced tracks remove the need to adjust the master level during the performance.

7 Show Mode

Show Mode is the performance interface. It presents large controls, the running order and live status, and restricts the operations available during a show.

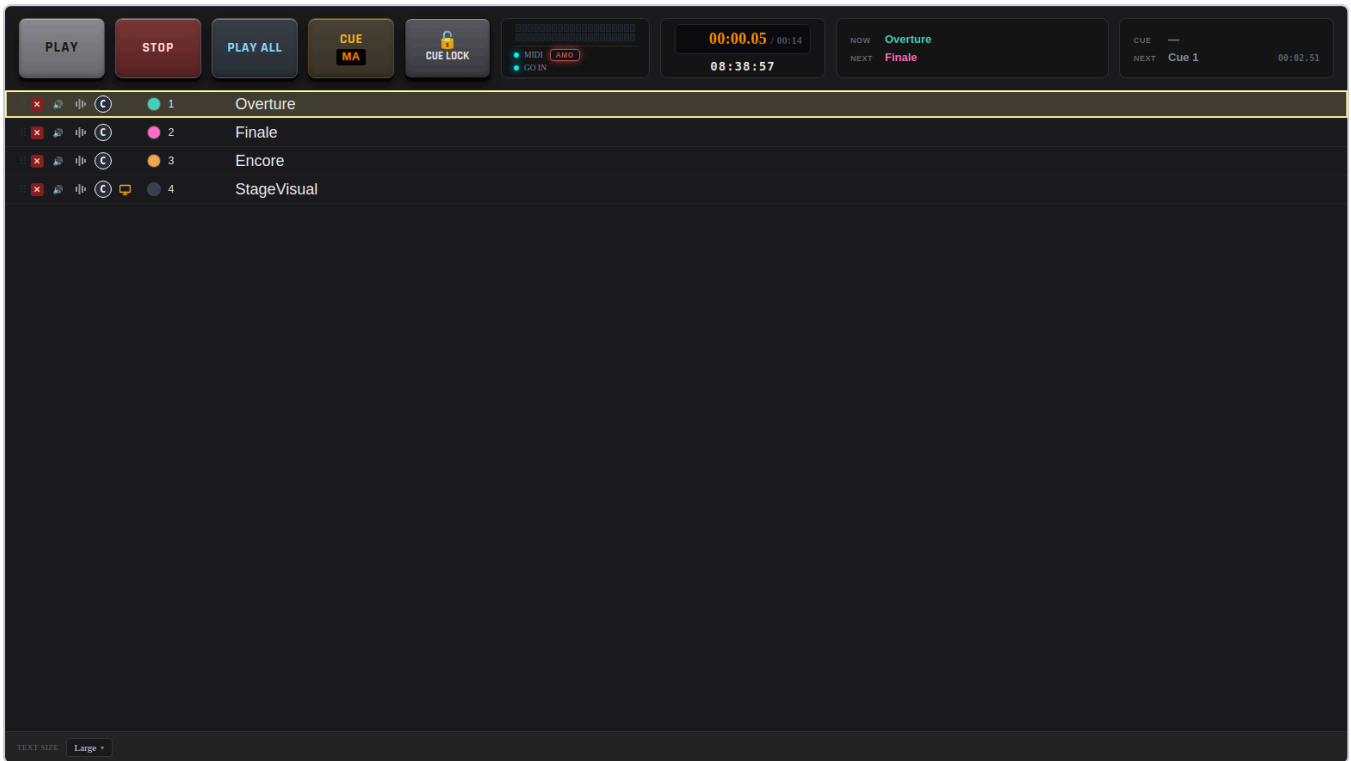


Figure 9. Show Mode before playback.

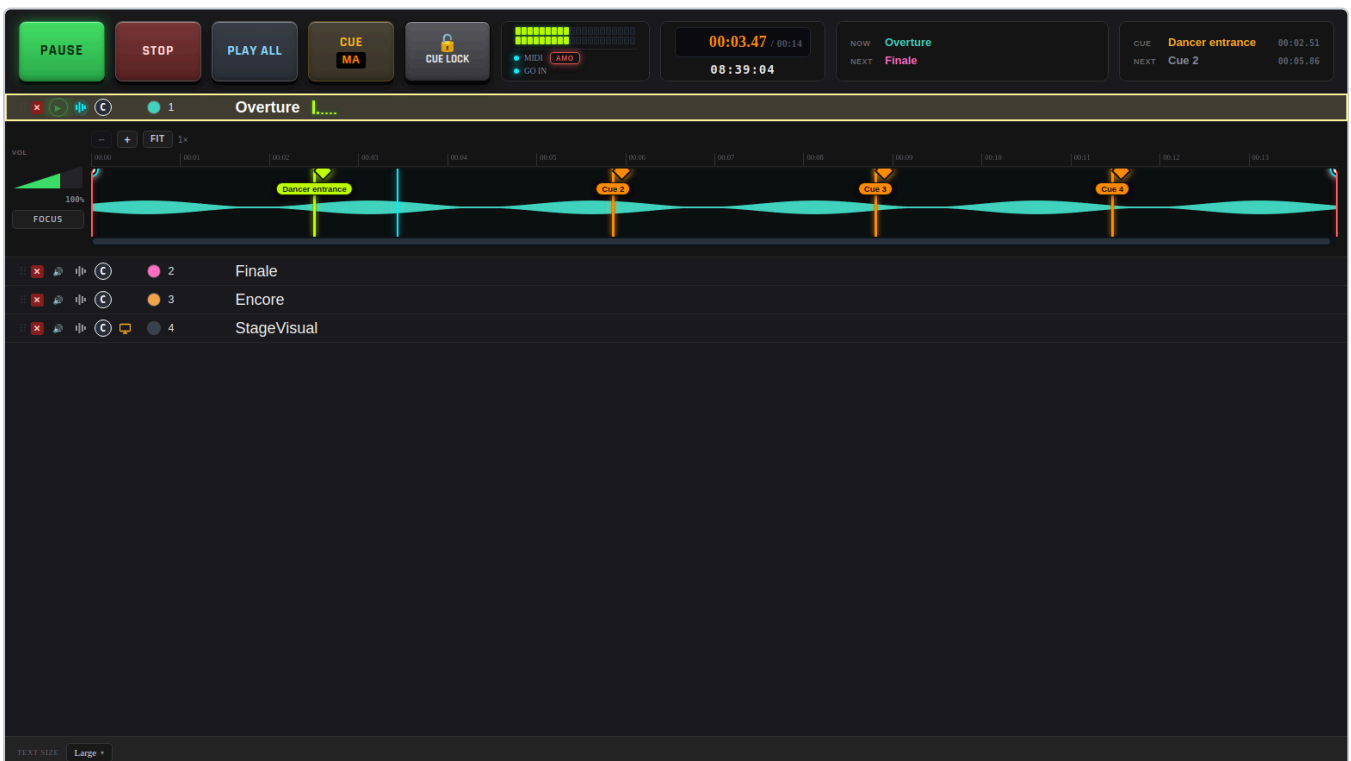


Figure 10. Show Mode during playback, with the waveform of the playing track expanded.

7.1 Top bar

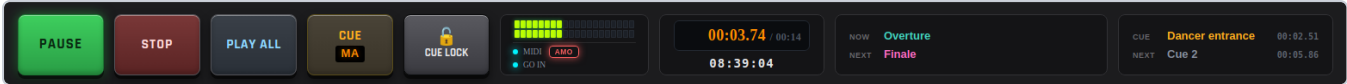


Figure 11. Transport, meter, clocks and status panels.

Element	Function
PLAY / PAUSE	Starts the selected song; reads PAUSE while playing.
STOP	Stops and returns to the start.
PLAY ALL	Continuous playback through the running order.
CUE / MA	Adds a cue at the playhead.
CUE LOCK	Locks all cues.
Meter and indicators	Output level, MIDI and GO IN status, AMO.
Clocks	Song elapsed / total time and time of day.
NOW / NEXT	The current song and the next song in the running order.
CUE / NEXT	The most recent cue passed and the next cue, each with its time.

7.2 Status panels

NOW / NEXT identifies the song the playhead is in and the song that follows. Both remain populated while paused, so the operator always sees the current position in the show. Long song names are truncated; hover to display the full title.

CUE / NEXT shows the last cue passed and the next to fire, updated continuously during playback, while paused and after seeking.

TIP

During a performance, monitor the CUE / NEXT panel rather than the waveform. It states what has fired and what fires next.

7.3 Running order

Each row shows remove, a play indicator, the waveform toggle, the **C** cue list, and the video preview button where applicable. The playing song is highlighted in its assigned colour.

8 The Show Mode Waveform

Select the waveform icon on a row to expand that song's waveform within Show Mode.

8.1 Zoom



Figure 12. Zoom controls.

- + and – step through zoom levels from 1× to 8×.

- **FIT** returns to the entire song across the width.
- When zoomed, the waveform scrolls and follows the playhead during playback. The scroll position is retained after seeking.

8.2 Channel strip

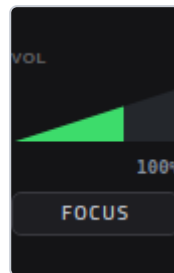


Figure 13. Volume control, level readout and the FOCUS button.

The triangular control sets the song's volume. Drag across it to change the level; the percentage is shown directly beneath it and updates during the drag.

FOCUS opens the song's processing strip in a floating window without leaving Show Mode.

8.3 Floating Focus window



Figure 14. Floating Focus window with the RTA enabled and the compressor active.

The window contains PAN, CURVE, the equaliser with RTA, and the compressor with its GR meter. Drag the title bar to reposition it; close it with the red ✕ at the top-left.

NOTE Volume and fade length are omitted from this window. Volume is adjusted with the triangular control beside FOCUS, and fades are set in Edit Mode.

9 Video

MP4, MOV, WebM and MKV files are accepted alongside audio. The audio is extracted and a waveform is drawn, so a video track supports cues, trimming and processing exactly as an audio track does.

- Video tracks display a screen icon in their row.
- Selecting the icon opens a preview window with no menu bar or player controls.
- The preview stays above other windows and remains synchronised with playback, including pause, stop and seek.

NOTE The preview window is muted deliberately. Sound is produced by Cue Sync's playback engine, which is the timing reference for all cues.

10 Preferences

Open **File** → **Preferences**. The application version is shown at the bottom-left of the window.

10.1 MIDI

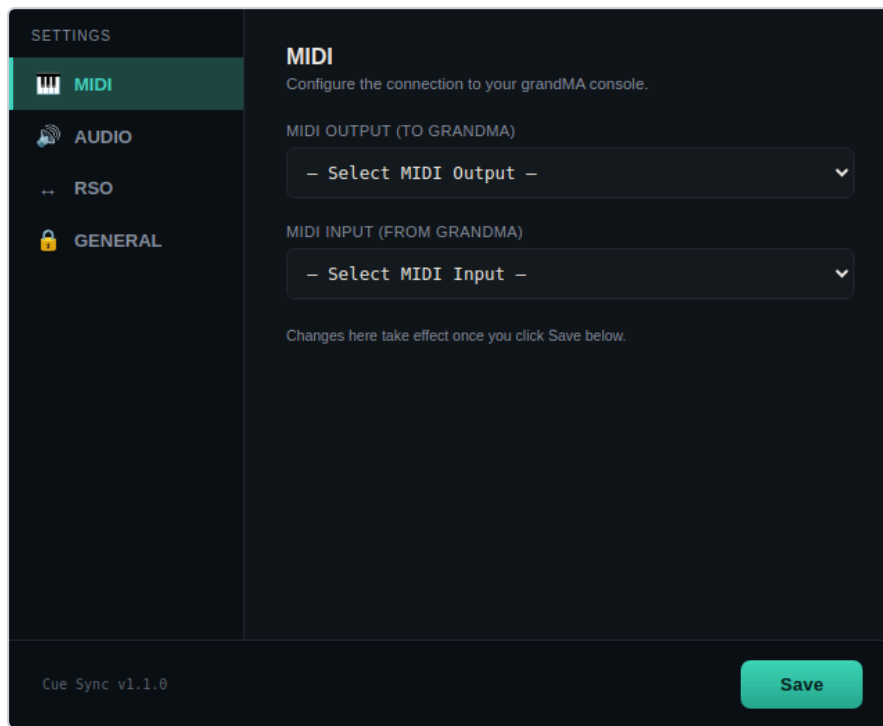


Figure 15. MIDI output and input selection.

1. Connect the MIDI interface, or start the virtual MIDI port.
2. Select the output port connected to the console.
3. Optionally select an input port so the console can trigger Cue Sync.
4. Confirm the link with **TEST SIGNAL**.

10.2 Audio

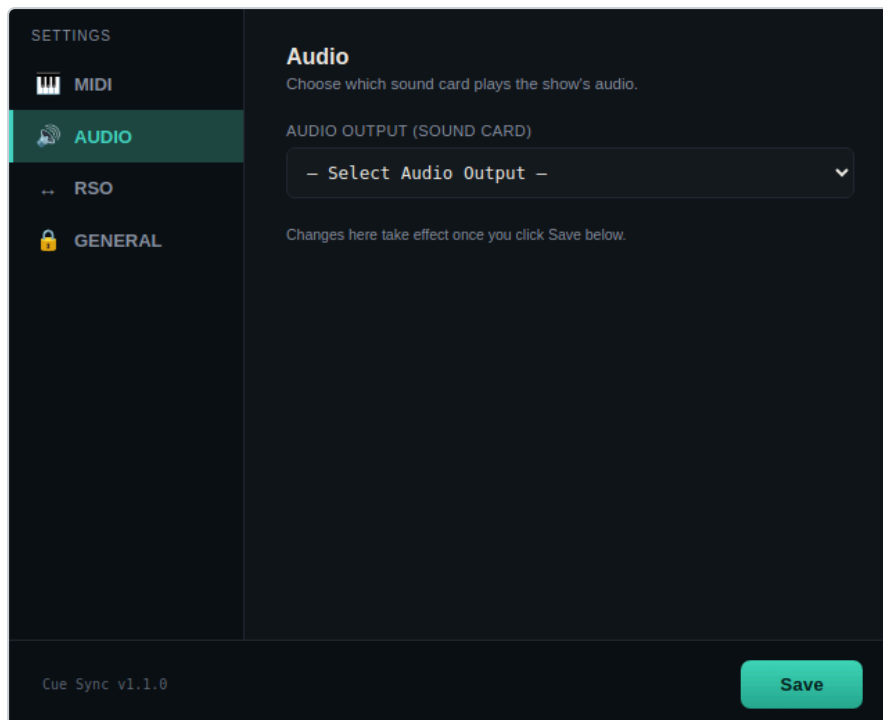


Figure 16. Audio output device.

10.3 RSO

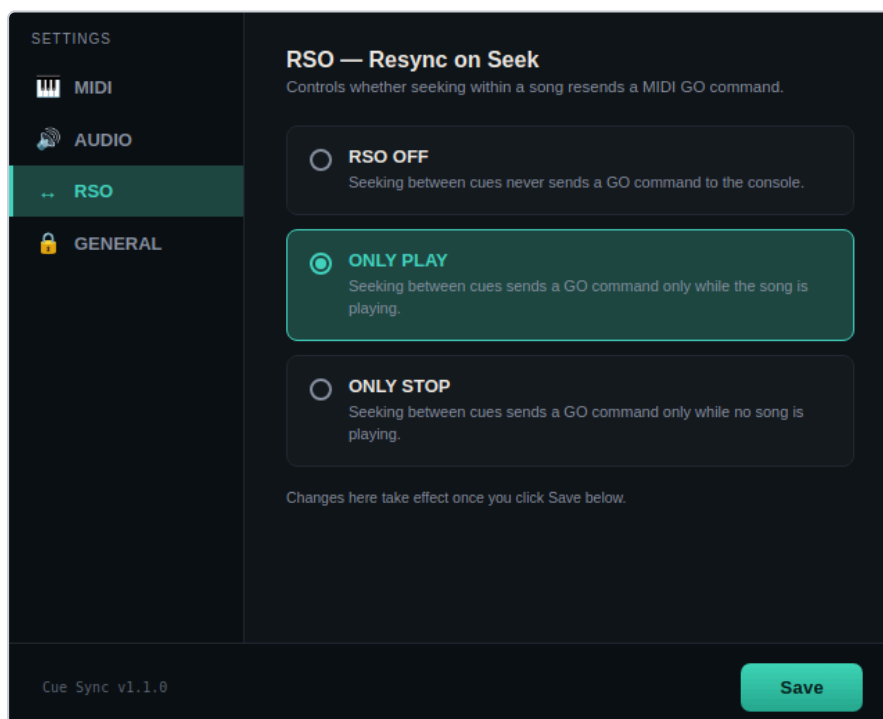


Figure 17. Remote behaviour.

10.4 General

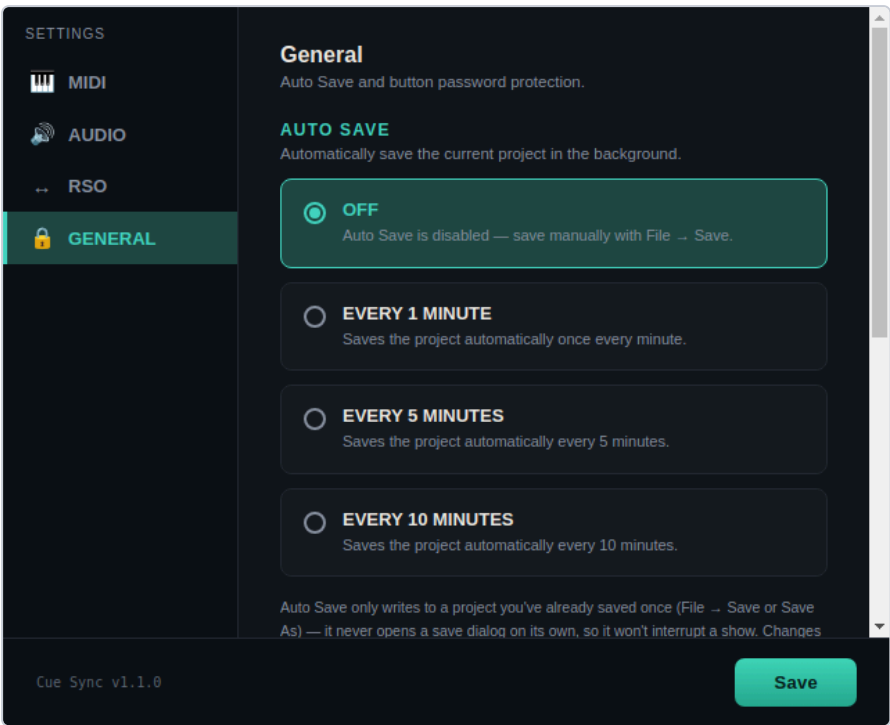


Figure 18. Auto Save and password protection.

Auto Save: OFF, or every 1, 5 or 10 minutes. Select **Save** for the setting to take effect.

CAUTION Auto Save writes only to a project that has already been saved once. It never opens a save dialog, so it cannot interrupt a performance, but it will not protect a project that has never been saved.

Password protection: when set, PLAY ALL, CUE LOCK and AMO request the password before acting.

TIP Verify the console link with TEST SIGNAL on arrival at every venue. MIDI ports can change when USB devices are reconnected.

11 Phone Remote

Cue Sync can serve a control page to any phone on the same local network. Select **Remote** in the menu to display the address, then open it in the phone's browser.

Function	Detail
Running order	Select the song to play next.
PLAY / STOP	Transport control.
CUE LOCK	Toggles the lock; shown red when engaged, matching the desktop application.
Current cue	Displayed beneath the name of the playing song.
Timing	Each song shows its length; the playing song shows a live countdown.

TIP

Add the page to the phone's home screen. It installs with the Cue Sync icon and opens full screen without the browser address bar.

12 Reference

12.1 Pre-show checklist

- ☐ Confirm the MIDI link with **TEST SIGNAL**.
- ☐ Confirm the audio output device in Preferences.
- ☐ Balance track levels in Focus Mode.
- ☐ Save the project, then enable Auto Save.
- ☐ Engage **CUE LOCK** once the cue plot is final.
- ☐ Create a **Backup Project** on a separate drive.

12.2 Troubleshooting

Symptom	Action
Console does not respond	Check the MIDI output port; confirm cue numbers match the console; confirm AMO has not disconnected MIDI.
No audio	Check Preferences → Audio, the track's volume control and the system output.
Cue cannot be moved	CUE LOCK is engaged; release it to edit.
Project does not auto-save	Save the project once manually; Auto Save writes only to an existing file.
macOS reports the app as damaged	Open with right-click → Open, or clear the quarantine flag (Chapter 2).
Application requests a serial after reinstalling	Expected behaviour; each installation is activated separately.
Video preview has no sound	Expected; audio is played by the playback engine.
Song name is truncated	Hover over the name to display the full title.

12.3 Glossary

Term	Definition
MSC	MIDI Show Control — a MIDI protocol for show equipment such as lighting consoles.
Cue	A MIDI message scheduled at a position on a track.
RTA	Real-time analyser — a display of the signal's frequency content.
GR	Gain reduction — the amount by which the compressor lowers the level.
AMO	Disconnects MIDI output.